The Nature of Time：A Reflective Study

A Thermodynamics Definition of Time and Its Philosophical Implications

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I. The Problem Stated

What is time? This is perhaps the oldest, most fundamental, and most perplexing question in physics.

Newton said time is absolute, flowing uniformly, a background independent of all things. Leibniz countered that time is nothing more than the ordering of events. Kant said time is a transcendental form of human sensible intuition. Einstein said time is a dimension of the spacetime manifold, inseparable from space, curved by the distribution of matter.

But none of these answers address a deeper question: **Why does time have a direction?**

In Newtonian mechanics, time reversal is symmetric—you cannot tell from the equations whether a film is playing forward or backward. The same holds in general relativity; Einstein's field equations are invariant under time reversal. Even the Schrödinger equation in quantum mechanics is time-reversal symmetric.

Yet the world we inhabit is obviously not like this. Cups break and do not spontaneously reassemble. Coffee cools and does not spontaneously heat up. We grow, age, and do not grow young. The second law of thermodynamics gives the only physical law with an explicit direction: the entropy of an isolated system never

decreases.

This constitutes a great chasm that has persisted in physics for over a century: microscopic laws are reversible, macroscopic phenomena are irreversible; the fundamental equations are time-symmetric, the evolution of the universe is time-asymmetric.

This essay attempts to present, based on a discrete spatial network model, a mechanism for the origin of the arrow of time, and to argue that time is fundamentally a **counting process**—the cumulative record of irreversible energy transfers across a spatial network.

II. Core Assumptions: Space as a Discrete Network

We first state the two fundamental assumptions of the model:

1. **Spatial Topological Invariance**: Space consists of a finite number of elementary units (called Space Elementary Quanta, or SEQ). The adjacency relations of these units remain unchanged throughout the entire evolution of the universe—no nodes are added or removed, no connections are broken or created.

2. **Energy-Gradient-Driven Rule**: Energy can only transfer from higher-energy nodes to adjacent lower-energy nodes, one fundamental unit at a time (Planck's constant h). The transfer direction follows the principle of maximum energy gradient.

Before examining the phenomenological consistency of the energy-gradient-driven postulate, its fundamental status must be clarified: this is a phenomenological-level postulate—it is not derived from any higher-level theory, but is directly posited as the underlying rule at the Planck scale: energy can only flow from higher-energy nodes to adjacent lower-energy nodes along the direction of maximum gradient. The value of this postulate lies in its capacity to systematically align, at the phenomenological level, with established physical theories. The driving force in F = ma can be reduced to the cumulative node-by-node migration of compressed regions driven by potential energy gradients; the second law of thermodynamics can be reduced to a direct algebraic

consequence of the necessary increase of multiplicative entropy $S = \prod m_i$ under this rule; the anisotropic energy gradient field formed by mass-induced spatial compression in general relativity can be reduced to the discrete version of the geodesic equation; the electric currents and forces driven by electric potential gradients in electrodynamics can be reduced to the cumulative coupling between the energy gradient field and the phase structure of charged particles. In other words, all the "driving terms" in classical mechanics, thermodynamics, general relativity, and electrodynamics—potential gradients, temperature gradients, curvature gradients, and electric potential gradients—are reducible at the phenomenological level to a single mechanism: energy transfers between adjacent Space Elementary Quanta along the direction of maximum gradient.

These two assumptions constitute the entire dynamical foundation of the model. On this basis, we define:

- The energy value of each node is a positive integer (in units of *h*)
- The total energy of the system is conserved (the sum of all node energies is constant)
- Entropy is defined as the product of all node energy values: $S = \prod m_i$

III. Time as Counting: The Derivation

Now, we derive the conclusions regarding the concept of time.

Theorem 1: Every energy transfer necessarily increases entropy.

Let the energy values of two adjacent nodes be *a* and *b*, where $a > b+1$ (the transfer condition is satisfied). After transferring one unit of energy, the state becomes $(a-1)$ and $(b+1)$.

The entropy ratio before and after transfer is:

$$S'/S = (a-1)(b+1)/(ab) = 1 + (a-b-1)/(ab)$$

Since $a-b-1 > 0$ and $ab > 0$, it follows that $S'/S > 1$. Entropy necessarily increases—not probabilistically, but deterministically.

Theorem 2: The entropy-increasing process is irreversible.

The reverse of the transfer would require energy to flow from the lower-energy node to the higher-energy node. The rule explicitly prohibits transfer in this direction. Therefore, irreversibility is built into the underlying rules from the outset.

Definition: Time T = the cumulative count of all energy transfer events in the network.

Under this definition:

1. Time is a positive integer (or a sequence of natural numbers starting from the initial state)

2. The increment of time is always positive ($\Delta T > 0$ for every transfer that occurs)

3. The passage of time is accompanied by a necessary increase in entropy

4. When the system reaches a completely uniform energy distribution (all m_i equal), transfers cease, and time increments terminate

This is a fully deterministic, non-statistical mechanism for the origin of the arrow of time.

IV. Phenomenological Consistency Checks of the Axiomatic System

Any theoretical axiomatic system, however internally consistent, is merely an elaborate mathematical game if it fails to correspond to observed phenomena. Therefore, we must examine whether the two axioms above (topological invariance + energy-gradient driving) can reproduce known physical phenomena.

Check 1: Gravitational Time Dilation in General Relativity

General Relativity predicts that proper time slows down in strong gravitational fields—that is, clocks close to massive objects run slower relative to observers far from the gravitational source. How does this model account for this?

In the model, when the "elastic connections" between SEQs (constituted by the sub-Planckian substrate) are compressed or stretched, their resonance frequency decreases (see Section 13 of the original text). A lower frequency means that, within the same external reference frame, the number of energy transfer events occurring per unit time decreases. Consequently, the cumulative rate of time (defined as the count of transfers) slows down. This is the microscopic mechanism of gravitational time dilation—without resorting to the geometric metaphor of "curved spacetime," but instead providing an operational counting discrepancy.

More importantly, this mechanism distinguishes between two types of time dilation: the time dilation caused by uniform motion in Special Relativity originates from counting differences in light-signal transmission (an observer effect); whereas the time dilation caused by gravitational fields and accelerated motion in General Relativity originates from physical deformation of the spatial network leading to frequency modulation (a physical effect). This distinction is fully compatible with existing experimental facts (such as GPS satellite clock corrections and the extended lifetimes of muons in particle accelerators).

Check 2: The Constancy and Limit of the Speed of Light

In the model, light is defined as a transverse resonance-spin coupled excitation wave on the SEQ network (see Section 14). Its propagation speed is determined entirely by the network's own elastic response speed and energy transfer rate. Therefore:

- The speed of light is an intrinsic property of the network, not of the emitter—this explains the Michelson-Morley experiment.

- Any material motion is merely a different excitation mode on the same network and cannot exceed the network's own maximum signal propagation speed—this explains the light-speed limit.

- The speed of light is the same in all reference frames because all reference frames are established on the same SEQ network—this explains the origin of Lorentz covariance.

Check 3: The Non-Statistical Validity of the Second Law of Thermodynamics

Traditional thermodynamics' second law is a statistical law—entropy increases "almost always," but occasional fluctuations allow entropy decreases. The

entropy-increase theorem of this model (Section III above), however, is an algebraic necessity: as long as $a > b+1$, the entropy after transfer is necessarily greater than before. There are no exceptions, no probabilities, no fluctuations.

This provides a completely new ontological foundation for the second law: it is not an approximate law emergent from the statistical behavior of a large number of particles, but a direct consequence of the energy-transfer rule itself. This explains why, in physical processes at all scales (from subatomic to cosmological), we have never observed an entropy-decreasing process—not because it is "extremely unlikely," but because "the rules do not permit it."

Check 4: Quantum Uncertainty and Wave-Particle Duality

The model views particles as localized excitation waves on the spatial network (see Section 1.7). A microscopic particle is actually an energy packet distributed across multiple SEQ nodes. Precisely determining its position requires localizing it to a single node, which necessarily loses information about its wavelength (which is much larger than the node spacing)—and vice versa. This is the natural geometric origin of the Heisenberg uncertainty principle.

The interference pattern in the double-slit experiment is interpreted as the result of cumulative phase differences among the multiple maximum-entropy paths along which a single particle propagates (see Section 7.3 and reference [32] for experimental evidence of physical delocalization of photons in interferometers). The model does not introduce wavefunction collapse or nonlocal interactions—interference is the statistical result of coherent superposition among paths.

Check 5: Consistency between Causality Direction and the Arrow of Time

Causality requires that causes precede effects. But in a time-reversal-symmetric physical theory, "precede" itself depends on the definition of time—creating a circular argument.

This model breaks this circularity: time is defined as the count of energy transfers, and the direction of energy transfer is fixed by the rule as high→low. Therefore, "causes" are those energy configurations that raise the rate of subsequent entropy production, and "effects" are the subsequent entropy-increasing events. The direction of causality and the direction of time are consistent—not by coincidence, but as two

aspects of the same rule.

Summary: The five checks above demonstrate that the two axioms of this model (topological invariance + energy-gradient driving) are not arbitrary assumptions. When supplemented with mechanisms such as the elastic structure of SEQs and resonance frequency modulation, they systematically reproduce and explain the core predictions of General Relativity, the foundational features of quantum mechanics, the irreversibility of thermodynamics, and several cosmological puzzles. This capacity to explain a wide range of known phenomena with a small set of axioms is the strongest evidence for the reasonableness of the theory.

V. Compatibility with and Supplement to Existing Physical Theories

How does the concept of time under this definition interface with existing physical theories?

Regarding Relativity: In General Relativity, gravitational fields cause time dilation. In this model, spatial compression or stretching alters the resonance frequency of SEQs (see Section 13 of the original text). A lower frequency means that, within unit external coordinate time, the count of energy transfers decreases. This is the physical mechanism of gravitational time dilation—not that time itself "slows down," but that the update rate of the network decreases.

Regarding Quantum Mechanics: In this model, quantum probability originates from the coexistence of multiple maximum-entropy paths (see Section 3.8). When the system faces multiple equivalent maximum-entropy paths at each step, their choices are equivalent. This non-uniqueness is the origin of quantum probability—not so-called "intrinsic randomness."

Regarding Thermodynamics: Traditional thermodynamic entropy is statistical, relying on coarse-graining assumptions. The entropy of this model, however, is analytic, deterministic, and computable point by point. It gives the microscopic necessity of the second law of thermodynamics, rather than a probabilistic interpretation. This is not a replacement of the entropy concept, but a deepening of it—at the Planck scale, statistical entropy can be reduced to analytic entropy.

VI. Philosophical Implications

If time is the count of energy transfers, the following implications are noteworthy:

First, the ontological status of time.

Time is not a transcendental container (Kant), nor an absolute uniformly flowing entity (Newton). Time is an intrinsic property of process—a marker of the sequence of network states. Without state change, there is no time. In this sense, time has a relational rather than a substantive ontology.

Second, the necessity of the arrow of time.

The thermodynamic arrow of time is not a consequence of initial conditions, not an illusion of statistical fluctuations, but a direct algebraic consequence of the underlying rule (energy can only flow from high to low). This resolves the classic problem of "why did the universe start in a low-entropy state"—even if the initial conditions were different, as long as the rule is the same, the entropy-increasing tendency still holds.

Third, the locality and globality of time.

Global time corresponds to the count of energy transfers across the entire network. Local time corresponds to the count of transfers within a specific region. The two need not be synchronized—this is the discrete version of "proper time" in General Relativity. Gravitational fields or high-speed motion cause local frequency changes, i.e., local counting-rate changes, manifesting as time dilation.

Fourth, the finitude of time.

Since the number of nodes N is finite and the total energy E is constant, the system has only a finite number of possible energy distribution states. Entropy has an upper bound (reached when all node energies are equal). Therefore, the time process is finite—the universe will eventually reach thermodynamic equilibrium, at which point transfers cease and time increments terminate.

VII. Potential Criticisms and Responses

Criticism 1: This model reduces time to a counter, ignoring the sense of direction

and the feeling of passage.

Response: Subjective time experience is the coupling between the observer's own internal state-update frequency (as part of the network) and external counting. The "passage" of experience does not mean that time itself is fundamentally flowing—just as the "motion" in a film does not mean that each frame itself moves. The directionality and passage of time are products of experience, not attributes of time's ontology.

Criticism 2: This model lacks mathematical rigor; it is merely an analogy.

Response: The entropy-increase theorem of this model has a rigorous algebraic proof. Its definition of time has an explicit construction on a finite-state network. The framework for interfacing with General Relativity and quantum field theory has been outlined in Sections 13–14 of the original text. Of course, the complete mathematical formalization of discretizing continuous geometric dynamics remains an open task—but this is a deficiency of mathematical technique, not a defect of the concept.

Criticism 3: This model is reductionist, reducing time to a sequence of state updates of a spatial network.

Response: This is not reductionism in the traditional sense. The model does not define time against a background of space; rather, it treats space itself as a dynamic network, and time and space are different aspects of this same entity—time measures its update ordering, space measures its adjacency structure. Both are attributes of the same entity, not a reduction of one to the other.

VIII. A Closing Reflection

We have presented a definition of time as the cumulative count of irreversible energy transfers across a discrete spatial network. This definition resolves the origin of the arrow of time not by appealing to probability or initial conditions, but by embedding irreversibility into the foundational dynamical rules themselves. It offers an operational concept of time compatible with gravitational time dilation, consistent with the probabilistic structure of quantum mechanics, and mathematically aligned with the second law of thermodynamics.

Yet we must acknowledge the position this theory occupies. If judged by the standard

of strict alignment with mainstream theoretical physics, this account of time is plainly not mainstream—it diverges from the established frameworks in its foundational assumptions and cannot be neatly reconciled with them. But if the criterion for progress were merely conformity to the established, no advance beyond the established would ever be possible. What this reflective study offers, instead, is a different standard of evaluation: logical self-consistency and conceptual clarity. When assessed on those grounds, this theory of time provides something that mainstream theories have not supplied: a fully explicit, step-by-step mechanistic account of why time has a direction, why entropy necessarily increases, and how the counting of microscopic transfers can give rise to the macroscopic arrow we all experience. Dear reader, if you find this theoretical framework persuasive, then please add it to your favorites.

Zou, Z. K. (2025). The Thermodynamic Arrow of Time in a Double-Layer Topology-Invariant Chiral Space with Geometric (GR) and Gauge (QFT) Degrees of Freedom : Time-Entropy Mapping; Mass-Gravity Duality; Metric-Frequency Mirroring. Preprints. https://doi.org/10.20944/preprints202505.0270.v12

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